

CivicAlert Karachi

Citizen Guide & Frequently Asked Questions

A comprehensive guide for citizens, administrators, and authorities using the CivicAlert civic issue reporting platform for Karachi.

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1. About CivicAlert Karachi

CivicAlert Karachi is a civic issue reporting and tracking platform designed specifically for the citizens of Karachi. It allows residents to report urban problems such as broken roads, garbage overflow, water shortages, sewerage leaks, streetlight failures, unsafe zones, and other civic infrastructure issues. The platform connects citizens directly with the relevant government departments responsible for resolving these issues.

The platform uses artificial intelligence to automatically route reports to the correct government department, verify the authenticity of reports through crowdsourced community verification, and provide real-time status tracking so citizens can follow the progress of their reported issues from submission to resolution.

Q: What is CivicAlert Karachi?

A: CivicAlert Karachi is a free civic issue reporting platform that enables citizens to report, track, and verify urban problems in Karachi. It connects citizens with relevant government departments like KWSB, SSWMB, KMC, K-Electric, and others to ensure faster resolution of civic issues.

Q: Who can use CivicAlert?

A: Any citizen of Karachi can create a free account and start reporting issues. You do not need any special permissions. The platform is available in both English and Urdu. Administrators and government officials use the platform to manage and resolve reported issues within their jurisdiction.

Q: Is CivicAlert free to use?

A: Yes, CivicAlert is completely free for all citizens. There are no charges for creating an account, reporting issues, or tracking reports.

Q: What areas of Karachi does CivicAlert cover?

A: CivicAlert covers all districts and towns within Karachi. When you submit a report and drop a pin on the map, the system automatically identifies which district and town the issue falls under. This includes areas across all 7 districts: Karachi Central, Karachi East, Karachi West, Karachi South, Korangi, Malir, and Kemari.

2. Account & Registration

Q: How do I create an account?

A: Visit the CivicAlert website or app and click 'Register'. You need to provide your full name, email address, phone number, and create a password. After registration, you will receive a welcome email confirming your account. You can then log in immediately and start reporting issues.

Q: What information is required to register?

A: You need to provide: (1) your full name, (2) a valid email address, (3) a phone number, and (4) a password. Your email will be used for login and receiving status updates about your reports.

Q: I forgot my password. How do I reset it?

A: Currently, please contact our support team for password reset assistance. We are working on adding a self-service password reset feature in a future update.

Q: Can I change my preferred language?

A: Yes. CivicAlert supports both English and Urdu. You can switch languages at any time using the language toggle (EN / ■■■■) in the navigation bar. Your preference is saved to your account.

Q: Is my personal information safe?

A: Yes. Your personal data is encrypted and stored securely. Your password is hashed using industry-standard BCrypt encryption. We use secure HTTP-only cookies for authentication. Your phone number and email are never shared publicly. Only authorized administrators can see reporter contact details when needed for follow-up.

3. Reporting Civic Issues

Q: How do I report a civic issue?

A: After logging in, click 'Report an Issue' from the dashboard. You will be guided through a simple step-by-step process: (1) Select a category for the issue (e.g., Pothole, Garbage, Water Shortage), (2) Enter a title and detailed description, (3) Click on the map to mark the exact location of the issue, (4) Upload a photo of the issue if available, (5) Mark it as an emergency if urgent, and (6) Submit. The system will automatically check your report and assign it to the correct government department.

Q: What categories of issues can I report?

A: CivicAlert supports the following categories: Pothole/Road Damage, Garbage Overflow, Water Shortage, Sewerage Leak, Broken Streetlight, Unsafe Zone/Security Concern, Electricity Issue (Load Shedding/Outage), and General Civic Complaint. Each category is automatically routed to the relevant department.

Q: How does the location pin work?

A: When creating a report, you will see a map of Karachi. Click anywhere on the map to drop a pin at the exact location of the issue. The map is restricted to Karachi boundaries. The system records the latitude and longitude coordinates and uses them to identify which district and town the issue is in. This helps route the report to the correct local authority.

Q: Can I upload photos with my report?

A: Yes, you can upload one photo per report. Supported formats are JPEG and PNG, with a maximum file size of 5MB. Photos help administrators and other citizens verify the issue. We recommend taking clear photos that show the problem clearly.

Q: What happens after I submit a report?

A: After submission, several things happen automatically: (1) Your report is reviewed by our AI content moderation system to ensure it is appropriate, (2) The AI classifies your report and assigns it to the correct government department (e.g., KWSB for water issues, SSWMB for garbage), (3) Your report appears on the public map with a 'Reported' status, (4) Other citizens can see and verify your report, (5) You will receive email notifications as the status of your report changes.

Q: Is there a limit on how many reports I can submit?

A: To prevent spam, there is a rate limit of one report per 10 minutes per user. This ensures the platform remains reliable and reports are genuine. If you try to submit too quickly, you will see a message asking you to wait.

Q: What is an emergency report?

A: If the civic issue poses an immediate danger to public safety (such as an exposed electrical wire, a major road collapse, severe flooding, or a gas leak), you can mark your report as an Emergency. Emergency reports receive higher priority scores, are highlighted to administrators, and appear in the Emergency Center for immediate attention. Only use this for genuinely urgent situations.

4. Report Status & Tracking

Q: How do I track my reports?

A: Click 'My Reports' in the navigation bar to see all reports you have submitted. Each report shows its current status, category, department assignment, and date. Click on any report to see full details including the status history timeline.

Q: What are the different report statuses?

A: Reports go through the following status flow: (1) Reported — Your report has been submitted and is visible to other citizens. (2) Verified — At least 3 other citizens have confirmed your report is genuine. (3) In Progress — An administrator has acknowledged the issue and work has started. (4) Resolved — The issue has been fixed. (5) Rejected — The report was reviewed and could not be verified or was found to be inaccurate. Emergency reports may also have an 'Escalated' status when they have been flagged for urgent attention.

Q: How does the priority score work?

A: Each report has a priority score calculated as: $\text{Priority Score} = (\text{Category Default Priority} \times 10) + (\text{Number of Confirmations} \times 5) + (\text{Emergency Bonus of 50 if marked emergency})$. Higher priority reports are shown first to administrators. This means issues that are confirmed by more citizens and marked as emergencies get faster attention.

Q: Will I receive notifications about my report?

A: Yes. You will receive email notifications when: (1) Your account is registered successfully, (2) Your report is submitted successfully, (3) Your report status changes (e.g., from Reported to Verified, or from In Progress to Resolved). You will also see notifications in the bell icon in the app navigation bar.

5. Crowdsourced Verification

Q: What is report verification?

A: Verification is a community-powered feature where citizens can confirm or dispute reports submitted by other users. If you see a report on the map and you have personally witnessed the same issue, you can click 'Yes, I confirm' to add your verification. This builds trust and helps authorities prioritize genuine issues.

Q: How do I verify a report?

A: Open any report from the map or report list by clicking on it. On the report detail page, you will see a verification section with two buttons: 'Yes, I confirm' and 'No, this is fake'. Click the appropriate button. Your vote is recorded anonymously. You can only verify each report once.

Q: Can I verify my own report?

A: No. You cannot verify a report that you submitted yourself. This prevents manipulation of the verification system and ensures fairness.

Q: How many verifications are needed?

A: A report needs at least 3 confirmations from different citizens to automatically change its status from 'Reported' to 'Verified'. Once verified, the report gets a higher priority score and is flagged for administrator attention.

Q: What happens if people dispute a report?

A: Dispute votes are recorded but do not currently affect the report status. If a report receives significantly more disputes than confirmations, administrators may review it manually. The system tracks all verification activity for transparency.

6. Government Departments

CivicAlert automatically routes your report to the correct government department using AI classification. Here are the departments in the system:

Department	Full Name	Handles
KWSB	Karachi Water & Sewerage Board	Water supply, sewerage, drainage, water tankers
SSWMB	Sindh Solid Waste Management Board	Garbage collection, waste overflow, street cleaning
KMC-Roads	KMC Roads Department	Potholes, road damage, footpaths, street lights
K-Electric	K-Electric	Load shedding, power outages, exposed wires, transformers
KMC-Parks	KMC Parks Department	Parks, recreational spaces, public gardens
Traffic-Police	Karachi Traffic Police	Traffic signals, congestion, violations
Sindh-Police	Sindh Police	Safety, harassment, theft, unsafe zones
NDMA	National Disaster Management	Flooding, heatwave, disaster alerts
KMC-General	KMC General Services	Other civic issues not listed above

Q: How does AI department routing work?

A: When you submit a report, our AI system reads your report title, description, and selected category. It then determines which government department is best suited to handle the issue. For example, a report about 'sewerage leak on main road' would be routed to KWSB. A report about 'garbage pile near school' would go to SSWMB. This happens automatically within seconds.

Q: What if the AI assigns the wrong department?

A: Administrators can manually reassign reports to a different department if the AI classification was incorrect. The AI system learns and improves over time, but manual oversight ensures accuracy.

7. Administration & Authority Workflow

Q: What are the different user roles?

A: CivicAlert has the following roles: (1) Citizen — Regular users who report and verify issues. (2) Town Admin — Administrators responsible for a specific town. They can see and manage only reports within their town. (3) District Admin — Administrators responsible for an entire district. They can see reports from all towns within their district. (4) Super Admin — System administrators with full access to all reports across all districts and towns.

Q: What can administrators do?

A: Administrators can: view analytics and statistics for their jurisdiction, see charts showing reports by category, status distribution, and trends over time, change report statuses (e.g., mark as In Progress or Resolved), escalate emergency reports, view which towns or categories have the most complaints, access a management dashboard with real-time data, and manage user accounts (Super Admin only).

Q: How does the admin dashboard work?

A: The admin dashboard has several sections: Overview (summary stats and recent activity), Analytics (charts and graphs with time filters for day/week/month/year), Reports (searchable and filterable table of all reports with action buttons), Emergency Center (dedicated view for emergency reports), and User Management (Super Admin only). District Admins see data for all towns in their district. Town Admins see only their town's data.

8. Map & Public Transparency

Q: How does the report map work?

A: The interactive map shows all civic issue reports across Karachi. Each report is displayed as a colored marker: Red for Reported issues, Blue for Verified issues, Orange for In Progress issues, and Green for Resolved issues. You can click on any marker to see the report summary and navigate to the full details. Filter controls let you narrow results by category, status, or emergency level.

Q: What is the Public Transparency Dashboard?

A: The Transparency Dashboard is a public page that anyone can access without logging in. It shows overall platform statistics including total reports, resolution rate, average resolution time, reports by category and district, and recently resolved issues. This promotes government accountability and shows citizens that the system is actively working to resolve issues.

Q: Can I see reports from other citizens?

A: Yes. All reports are visible on the public map and in the report listings. This transparency allows citizens to see what issues exist in their neighborhood, verify reports they have witnessed, and hold authorities accountable for resolution. Personal contact details of reporters are not publicly visible.

9. AI-Powered Features

Q: How does content moderation work?

A: Every report submitted is automatically screened by our AI moderation system. It checks for inappropriate content including hate speech, profanity, threats, spam, and non-civic content. If your report is flagged, you will see a message explaining why, and you can revise and resubmit. This ensures the platform remains professional and focused on genuine civic issues.

Q: Does CivicAlert protect against fake reports?

A: Yes, multiple layers protect against fake or spam reports: (1) AI content moderation screens every report before it is saved. (2) Rate limiting allows only one report per 10 minutes per user. (3) Crowdsourced verification requires 3 citizen confirmations before a report is promoted. (4) Prompt injection detection prevents attempts to manipulate the AI system. (5) Administrator oversight allows manual review and rejection of suspicious reports.

Q: What is the CivicAlert chatbot?

A: The CivicAlert chatbot is an AI-powered assistant available on the Help page. You can ask it questions about how to use the platform, reporting procedures, verification, department routing, and more. It supports both English and Urdu. The chatbot uses a knowledge base to provide accurate answers specific to CivicAlert.

10. Troubleshooting & Technical Questions

Q: I am getting a 'rate limit' error when reporting.

A: You can only submit one report every 10 minutes. Please wait and try again. This limit exists to prevent spam and ensure platform reliability.

Q: My report was blocked by content moderation. What do I do?

A: Review the reason provided by the AI. Common reasons include inappropriate language, content not related to a civic issue, or suspicious patterns. Revise your title and description to clearly describe a legitimate civic problem, then resubmit.

Q: The map is not loading properly.

A: The map requires an internet connection to load OpenStreetMap tiles. Check your internet connection and refresh the page. If you are on a slow connection, the map may take longer to load. The map is optimized for low-bandwidth connections.

Q: Can I use CivicAlert on my mobile phone?

A: Yes. CivicAlert is designed to be mobile-friendly and works on any smartphone browser. The interface adapts to your screen size. It is also designed to work on low-end Android devices and slow internet connections.

Q: How do I contact CivicAlert support?

A: You can use the in-app chatbot on the Help page for immediate assistance. For account-related issues, email support@civicalert.pk. For urgent platform issues, contact our team through the platform's official channels.

Q: What technologies power CivicAlert?

A: CivicAlert uses a modern technology stack: ASP.NET Core Web API for the backend, React with TypeScript for the frontend, SQL Server for the database, FastAPI (Python) for AI microservices, Mistral AI for content moderation and department classification, Pinecone vector database for the RAG chatbot, Leaflet and OpenStreetMap for mapping, and SignalR for real-time notifications.